

U.S. Economic Indicators

Wednesday, September 23, 2026
Market data as of Sep 22, 2026 close (EFA/EEM: Sep 21)

Nonfarm payrolls · Aug +162K vs +55K consensus	Unemployment · Aug 4.1% in line; U-6 7.7%	CPI YoY · Aug 3.4% core 2.4%, core MoM 0.3% hot	Fed funds target 3.75–4.00% +25 bp hike on Sep 16	S&P 500 7,764.64 +13.4% YTD	10-yr Treasury 4.96% +78 bp YTD
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The week in one paragraph

The labor market re-accelerated in August — payrolls +162K against a 55K consensus, June–July revised up, and initial claims back under 200K — just as inflation proved sticky: headline CPI held at 3.4% with a hot 0.3% core print and PPI climbed to 5.4% on energy. That combination pushed the Fed to its first hike under Chair Warsh (+25 bp to 3.75–4.00% on Sep 16). Rate-sensitive housing is the casualty: builder sentiment hit a one-year low, starts and permits missed, and the 30-yr mortgage rate is back near 7% with the 10-yr near 5%. Manufacturing surveys remain in expansion (ISM 54.6) even as factory output stalled. Equities have looked through it, with the S&P 500 up 13.4% YTD.

On deck

Thu 9/24	Initial jobless claims (wk 9/19)
Fri 9/25	UMich sentiment, September final
Tue 9/29	JOLTS job openings, August
Fri 10/2	Employment Situation, September
Wed 10/14	CPI, September
Thu 10/15	PPI, September

Labor Market

Indicator	Prior period			Latest period			Notes	Source
	Period	Cons.	Actual	Period	Cons.	Actual		
Initial Jobless Claims (000s)	Wk 9/5	205	206	Wk 9/12	207	196	4-wk avg 203.3K; lowest-since-1969 territory	DOL ETA
Continuing Claims (000s)	Wk 8/29	—	1,774	Wk 9/5	1,779	1,730	Lowest since Jan-2024; wk 8/29 rev. to 1,769K	DOL ETA
ADP Private Employment (000s)	Jul	75	44	Aug	47	38	Jul revised to +46K; slowest month since Jan	ADP NER
Nonfarm Payrolls (000s)	Jul	80	−23	Aug	55	162	Jul rev. to +21K; Jun+Jul net +55K revision	BLS CES
Private Payrolls	Jul	78	30	Aug	45	127	Consensus: LSEG	BLS CES
Manufacturing Payrolls	Jul	—	5	Aug	—	16	No public consensus	BLS CES
Unemployment Rate	Jul	4.2%	4.1%	Aug	4.1%	4.1%	U-6 7.7%; participation 61.6% (Aug)	BLS CPS
UMich Consumer Sentiment	Aug (F)	51.0	51.7	Sep (P)	51.0	47.8	Sep final due Fri 9/25; 1-yr infl. exp. 4.6%	UMich SCA
JOLTS Job Openings (000s)	Jun	7,400	7,359	Jul	7,300	7,271	Jun revised to 7,182K; Aug due Tue 9/29	BLS JOLTS

Personal / Household Sector

Indicator	Prior period			Latest period			Notes	Source
	Period	Cons.	Actual	Period	Cons.	Actual		
Consumer Credit (\$B)	Jun	11.9	14.2	Jul	11.3	18.1	Nonrevolving +\$15.3B, biggest since Jun-2023	Fed G.19
Personal Income (MoM)	Jun	0.3%	0.2%	Jul	0.2%	0.4%	Saving rate 3.0% (Jul)	BEA PI&O
Personal Spending (MoM)	Jun	0.4%	0.3%	Jul	0.1%	0.2%	Real PCE flat in Jul	BEA PI&O
Retail Sales (MoM)	Jul	0.1%	−0.6%	Aug	0.8%	1.2%	Strongest month since March	Census MARTS
Ex Auto & Gas	Jul	—	−0.2%	Aug	—	1.2%	Ex-autos Aug +1.4% vs +0.6% est.	Census MARTS

Industrial & Manufacturing Sector

Indicator	Prior period			Latest period			Notes	Source
	Period	Cons.	Actual	Period	Cons.	Actual		
Industrial Production (MoM)	Jul	0.3%	0.2%	Aug	0.3%	0.0%	Mfg output −0.3% in Aug, first drop of 2026	Fed G.17
Capacity Utilization	Jul	—	76.3%	Aug	—	76.3%		Fed G.17
Durable Goods Orders (MoM)	Jun	1.8%	0.3%	Jul	0.5%	1.1%	Ex-transport Jul +0.4% vs +0.6% est.	Census M3
Factory Orders (MoM)	Jun	0.2%	−0.3%	Jul	0.6%	0.9%	Ex-transport +0.6% (Jul)	Census M3
ISM Manufacturing PMI	Jul	53.9	55.6	Aug	55.2	54.6	Prices paid 71.1	ISM
ISM Services PMI	Jul	54.5	54.1	Aug	54.1	55.4	Prices paid 72.6	ISM
NFIB Small Business Optimism	Jul	97.5	99.8	Aug	99.3	98.7	Still above 52-yr avg of 98	NFIB
Leading Economic Index (MoM)	Jul	—	0.2%	Aug	—	−0.1%	First decline since March	Conference Board
Construction Spending (MoM)	Jun	0.2%	−0.1%	Jul	0.0%	−0.5%	Lowest level since Oct-2023	Census C30

Housing Market

Indicator	Prior period			Latest period			Notes	Source
	Period	Cons.	Actual	Period	Cons.	Actual		
NAHB Housing Market Index	Aug	33	35	Sep	34	32	One-year low; 38% of builders cutting prices	NAHB
Housing Starts (000s)	Jul	1,345	1,239	Aug	1,320	1,275		Census NRC
% Month over Month	Jul	—	−12.4%	Aug	—	−2.6%		Census NRC
Building Permits (000s)	Jul	1,375	1,443	Aug	1,408	1,394		Census NRC
% Month over Month	Jul	—	5.0%	Aug	—	−2.7%		Census NRC
Existing Home Sales (mil.)	Jul	4.05	4.06	Aug	3.98	3.98	Median price \$429,100 (+1.6% YoY)	NAR
% Month over Month	Jul	—	−1.7%	Aug	—	−2.0%		NAR
Pending Home Sales (MoM)	Jun	—	−5.4%	Jul	0.3%	−2.3%	Lowest level since Jan-2026	NAR
New Home Sales (000s)	Jun	607	628	Jul	620	607	Aug report is the next release	Census NRS
% Month over Month	Jun	—	1.6%	Jul	—	−10.5%		Census NRS
Case-Shiller 20-City (YoY, NSA)	May	—	1.6%	Jun	—	2.1%	Computed from S&P CoreLogic index via FRED	S&P DJI
Freddie Mac 30-Yr Mortgage	9/10	—	6.76%	9/17	—	6.95%	MBA apps −4.1% wk of 9/11	Freddie Mac PMMS

Inflation

Indicator	Prior period			Latest period			Notes	Source
	Period	Cons.	Actual	Period	Cons.	Actual		
CPI (MoM)	Jul	0.1%	0.1%	Aug	0.4%	0.4%	Gasoline +3.9% in Aug	BLS CPI
CPI (YoY)	Jul	3.4%	3.4%	Aug	3.3%	3.4%	Aug YoY consensus: FactSet median	BLS CPI
Ex Food & Energy (MoM)	Jul	0.2%	0.2%	Aug	0.2%	0.3%		BLS CPI
Ex Food & Energy (YoY)	Jul	2.5%	2.5%	Aug	2.4%	2.4%	Lowest since Mar-2021	BLS CPI
PPI Final Demand (MoM)	Jul	0.2%	0.0%	Aug	0.4%	0.4%	Jul revised to +0.1%	BLS PPI
PPI Final Demand (YoY)	Jul	4.9%	4.7%	Aug	5.3%	5.4%	Energy +24% YoY	BLS PPI
Ex Food & Energy (MoM)	Jul	0.3%	0.2%	Aug	0.3%	0.2%		BLS PPI
Ex Food & Energy (YoY)	Jul	4.2%	4.2%	Aug	4.6%	4.6%		BLS PPI
Core PCE (YoY)	Jun	—	3.3%	Jul	—	3.3%	Headline PCE 3.7% (Jul)	BEA PI&O
Core PCE (QoQ SAAR)	Q1	—	4.4%	Q2	—	3.6%	Current vintage; Q2 advance print was 3.4%	BEA NIPA

Real GDP (QoQ SAAR)

	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
2025	−0.6%	3.8%	4.4%	0.5%
2026	2.1%	1.5%	—	—

GDPNow Q3 2026: **5.1%**
Unit labor costs (SAAR) — Q1 2026: 1.3% · Q2 2026: 1.2%
ECI (QoQ) — Q1 2026: 0.9% · Q2 2026: 0.9%

Real GDP, QoQ SAAR, current vintage. 2026 Q2 = second estimate (third estimate pending). GDPNow = Atlanta Fed latest nowcast.

BEA · Atlanta Fed · BLS

Forecasts & Targets

IMF GDP	U.S.	World
2026	2.3%	3.0%
2027	2.2%	3.4%
July 2026 WEO Update		
MS S&P 500, YE 2026		8,000
MS S&P 500, mid-2027		8,300
MS EPS 2026E / 2027E	\$339 /	\$380
P/E on MS 2026E		22.9x

Targets set May 13, 2026. Per public press reporting of Morgan Stanley research; MS GDP and 10-yr targets are not publicly reported — confirm against internal research before client use.

IMF WEO · public press coverage of MS Research

Markets

	Level	2025	YTD
S&P 500	7,764.64	16.4%	13.4%
Dow Jones	51,863.69	13.0%	7.9%
NASDAQ Comp.	27,244.28	20.4%	17.2%
EAFE (EFA)	\$106.13	27.0%	10.5%
Emerging Mkts (EEM)	\$68.83	30.8%	25.8%
	End-2025	Now	Chg
10-Yr Treasury	4.18%	4.96%	+78 bp
30-Yr Treasury	4.84%	5.29%	+45 bp

Price returns. Treasury yields: end-2025 vs Sep 21, 2026 (constant maturity).

FRED · U.S. Treasury

Method. Actual = value as first published on release day (ALFRED vintage), cross-checked against the agency release. Later revisions appear in Notes. Consensus = Bloomberg survey median as reported in First Trust Data Watch; Dow Jones, LSEG, Reuters or FactSet where noted or where Bloomberg is not public. “—” = no public consensus. **Green** = better than consensus; **rust** = worse (for inflation, claims and unemployment, lower is better). Not investment advice.